MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 2 — Unit 2: Drama

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

In Christopher Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus*, a brilliant scholar trades his soul for power and discovers that unlimited ambition can produce a painfully wasted life.

Start with a picture

Imagine a clever student offered a shortcut: "You can have extraordinary powers now, but later you must pay a terrible price." The student signs without properly facing the consequences. This is an analogy for the bargain, not a suggestion that ordinary learning is dangerous.

Meet the main figures

- **Faustus:** a highly educated man dissatisfied with ordinary knowledge.
- **Mephistopheles:** the devil who serves him under Lucifer's authority.
- **Lucifer:** the ruler of the devils in the play.
- **Good and Evil Angels:** figures expressing opposed moral possibilities.
- **Wagner:** Faustus's servant, whose behaviour sometimes echoes his master's.
- **The Old Man:** a figure urging repentance late in the play.
- **The Chorus:** a voice that introduces and comments on the action.

Follow the story

1. Ordinary learning no longer satisfies him

Faustus considers fields such as medicine, law, logic, and theology. He wants something beyond their limits. Magic seems to promise godlike power.

His problem is not simply curiosity. His desire for knowledge becomes entangled with pride and domination.

2. He makes a bargain

Faustus agrees to give his soul to Lucifer in exchange for twenty-four years of service from Mephistopheles. He signs in blood. Warnings appear, but he pushes them aside.

3. Warnings compete with temptation

The Good Angel urges him towards repentance; the Evil Angel encourages his ambition. Mephistopheles himself describes the suffering of separation from God. Faustus therefore receives warnings from unexpected directions.

4. Great promises become small performances

Faustus initially dreams of enormous achievements. Much of his power is then spent on spectacle, jokes, court entertainment, and satisfying desires. Episodes involving the Pope, a knight, and out-of-season grapes reveal the gap between aspiration and achievement.

Think of someone given a vast library who uses it only to look up party tricks. The sadness lies partly in wasted possibility.

5. The deadline approaches

Faustus experiences fear and considers repentance, but repeatedly turns away or gives in to despair. In the final scene, his language becomes urgent as he tries to stop time. The devils carry him away.

Understand the big ideas

Ambition and the overreacher

An **overreacher** tries to exceed accepted human limits. Faustus represents the excitement of Renaissance aspiration and the danger of turning that aspiration into destructive self-importance.

Free will and fate

The play repeatedly presents choices, but it also makes us ask how fear, temptation, religious belief, and despair limit the ability to choose. Different critical readings give these pressures different weights.

Sin, repentance, and despair

The play asks whether Faustus will seek mercy. His belief that he cannot be forgiven becomes part of his tragedy. Explain this as the play’s religious and psychological conflict; do not treat it as a statement about every religious tradition.

Morality play and tragedy together

Angels, devils, the Seven Deadly Sins, and the struggle for a soul come from morality-play traditions. Faustus’s individual intelligence, ambition, fear, and suffering make the story a personal tragedy too.

Language and structure

Marlowe’s blank verse gives grandeur to Faustus’s desires. Comic episodes can expose how low those desires have fallen. The final movement sharply changes the sense of time: twenty-four years have passed, yet even an hour now feels precious.

Remember these words

- **Necromancy:** magic associated with summoning spirits or the dead.

- **Repentance:** turning away from wrongdoing towards moral or religious renewal.
- **Hamartia:** a tragic error or failing; how exactly it applies here is open to interpretation.
- **Soliloquy:** a speech revealing a character's thoughts, often while alone.

Build an exam answer

For "Faustus as a Renaissance hero," explain his thirst for knowledge, his wish to exceed limits, and his individual will. Then show how pride, distraction, and despair undermine those possibilities. Support the argument with the bargain, trivial performances, and final speech.

Quick check

1. How long does the bargain last? **Twenty-four years.**
2. Why are the comic episodes important? **They expose the distance between his ambitions and achievements.**
3. What makes the ending tragic beyond punishment? **The audience sees a capable person waste his potential.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Discuss Doctor Faustus as a tragedy of ambition and wasted human potential.

Expanded discussion

Faustus is compelling because his initial desire appears larger than ordinary satisfaction. He has mastered respected disciplines but wants knowledge and power beyond their limits. This aspiration connects him with Renaissance interest in human possibility. However, Marlowe also exposes the pride that converts learning into a wish for domination. Faustus does not merely want to understand the world; he imagines placing himself above its restrictions.

The bargain gives dramatic form to that misdirected aspiration. Twenty-four years of supernatural service are exchanged for the soul, while warnings make the consequences visible. The Good and Evil Angels externalise opposing impulses, and Mephistopheles unexpectedly provides a powerful description of spiritual loss. Faustus's tragedy consequently depends on his repeated response to knowledge he already possesses, not simply on ignorance of the danger.

The contrast between imagined greatness and actual achievement deepens the tragedy. Court entertainment, practical jokes, and sensual distractions replace the grand projects he once described. The comic scenes can therefore be read as evidence of moral and intellectual decline. In the final hour, the confident language of mastery gives way to desperate appeals against time. His inability to turn desire into meaningful achievement makes the ending a loss of human potential as well as a religious catastrophe.

A balanced reading should consider repentance and despair without assuming that the play settles every theological difficulty. Faustus repeatedly appears able to turn back, yet fear and his belief in the inevitability of damnation undermine that possibility. This tension allows the

play to work both as a warning and as a deeply disturbing account of human self-division.

Suggested answer structure

1. Introduce ambition and Renaissance aspiration
2. Analyse the bargain
3. Explain warnings and inner conflict
4. Contrast promise with trivial achievement
5. Read the final hour and evaluate the tragic loss

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not say the play condemns all education. Separate the desire to learn from pride, domination, and the choices made to gain power.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Additional scenes and figures to use as evidence

The Seven Deadly Sins turn temptation into a theatrical spectacle. The Old Man urges a possibility of moral return, while the appearance of Helen offers another compelling image of desire and distraction. Wagner and the comic figures can echo and diminish their master’s ambitions. The closing Chorus returns to the shape of a moral warning after the intense inward crisis of the final speech.

Three critical approaches in the assignments

As a morality play, the work stages opposed moral choices and the struggle for a soul. As tragedy, it encourages pity and fear through a gifted person’s repeated errors and destructive outcome. A psychological reading attends to self-division, avoidance, anxiety, and despair; the phrase “neurotic tragedy” in an assignment is a critical approach, not a clinical diagnosis of a real person.

Religious readings need historical care. Faustus is associated with Wittenberg, and the play emerged in a period shaped by Protestant debate. Questions of repentance, salvation, scripture, and predestination can inform interpretation, but do not assume every character speaks an uncontested Protestant doctrine. Distinguish predestination as a theological issue from Faustus’s own despairing assumptions.

The 1604 A-text and the longer 1616 B-text differ. Scene numbering, wording, and some episodes vary between editions. Use the course’s edition for exact quotations and act-and-scene references; do not silently combine incompatible versions.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit’s assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Discuss Doctor Faustus as a play in the tradition of English morality.
2. Discuss the Aristotelean components of tragedy in Doctor Faustus.
3. Examine how English Protestantism is represented in Doctor Faustus.
4. Analyse how Doctor Faustus tries to change from a comedy of evil to a tragedy of human bravery.
5. Consider Marlowe’s dramatic and intellectual accomplishments in Doctor Faustus.
6. Analyse Doctor Faustus as a neurotic tragedy and compare it to the plight of modern man.